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1000 Reflective Questions for MEL Practitioners — Starter 250

A rigorous, field-ready set of reflection prompts across 12 MEL domains.

Numbered list • Organised by domain

Design & Theory of Change

- 1. What is the explicit causal pathway from activities to outcomes in this program?
- 2. Which assumptions must hold for the pathway to work in the field?
- 3. What enabling conditions are outside our control yet critical to success?
- 4. Where might feedback loops amplify or dampen the intended effect?
- 5. Which outcomes could plausibly move non-linearly (thresholds, tipping points)?
- 6. What negative or perverse incentives could our activities create?
- 7. Which complementary interventions would strengthen the mechanism?
- 8. What early signals would indicate the theory is not working as expected?
- 9. How robust is the design to implementation variability across sites?
- 10. Which risks are worth taking given potential upside for equity?
- 11. What are the clear ‘stop’ or ‘pivot’ criteria in the design?
- 12. How would we adapt if an external shock changes key constraints?
- 13. What is the explicit causal pathway from activities to outcomes in this program—for rural and tribal geographies?
- 14. Which assumptions must hold for the pathway to work in the field—for peri-urban settlements with informal tenure?
- 15. What enabling conditions are outside our control yet critical to success—for conflict-affected or high-migration areas?
- 16. Where might feedback loops amplify or dampen the intended effect—for coastal and flood-prone districts?
- 17. Which outcomes could plausibly move non-linearly (thresholds, tipping points)—in digital-first delivery models?
- 18. What negative or perverse incentives could our activities create—during a rapid pilot (≤ 3 months)?

- 19. Which complementary interventions would strengthen the mechanism—during scale-up across multiple districts?
- 20. What early signals would indicate the theory is not working as expected—for adolescents (10–19) and youth (15–24)?
- 21. How robust is the design to implementation variability across sites—for women and girls facing mobility constraints?
- 22. Which risks are worth taking given potential upside for equity—for persons with disabilities?
- 23. What are the clear 'stop' or 'pivot' criteria in the design—for migrant workers and seasonal labour?
- 24. How would we adapt if an external shock changes key constraints—for linguistic minorities and low-literacy groups?

Measurement & Indicators

- 25. Are indicators measuring constructs directly or proxies—and what is lost?
- 26. Which indicators matter most for decision-makers and on what cadence?
- 27. Do indicator definitions align with national/SDG standards for comparability?
- 28. Where is misclassification most likely in our measurement system?
- 29. Are time windows appropriate to detect meaningful change?
- 30. What disaggregations (sex, caste, disability, wealth, location) are essential?
- 31. Are there leading indicators that give earlier insight than outcomes?
- 32. Which measures capture quality, not just quantity?
- 33. How will we handle values below detection limits or above instrument range?
- 34. What is our plan for indicator validation (re-measurement, record checks)?
- 35. Where should we prefer rates over counts (or vice-versa) to avoid bias?
- 36. What metadata must be stored to make indicators reusable and auditable?
- 37. Are indicators measuring constructs directly or proxies—and what is lost—within government frontline systems?
- 38. Which indicators matter most for decision-makers and on what cadence—with community-based organisations as implementers?
- 39. Do indicator definitions align with national/SDG standards for comparability—with private providers or PPP arrangements?
- 40. Where is misclassification most likely in our measurement system—for rural and tribal geographies?

- 41. Are time windows appropriate to detect meaningful change—for peri-urban settlements with informal tenure?
- 42. What disaggregations (sex, caste, disability, wealth, location) are essential—for conflict-affected or high-migration areas?
- 43. Are there leading indicators that give earlier insight than outcomes—for coastal and flood-prone districts?
- 44. Which measures capture quality, not just quantity—in digital-first delivery models?
- 45. How will we handle values below detection limits or above instrument range—during a rapid pilot (≤ 3 months)?
- 46. What is our plan for indicator validation (re-measurement, record checks)—during scale-up across multiple districts?
- 47. Where should we prefer rates over counts (or vice-versa) to avoid bias—for adolescents (10–19) and youth (15–24)?
- 48. What metadata must be stored to make indicators reusable and auditable—for women and girls facing mobility constraints?

Sampling & Data Quality

- 49. Which populations are systematically missed by our sampling frame?
- 50. What is the practical trade-off we made between representativeness and cost?
- 51. Where is non-response most concentrated, and is it ignorable?
- 52. How will we diagnose and handle missingness (MCAR/MAR/MNAR)?
- 53. What is our protocol for enumerator training, drift checks, and retraining?
- 54. Which paradata fields will we collect and monitor for quality?
- 55. How will we detect outliers without erasing meaningful heterogeneity?
- 56. What proportion of records will be back-checked and by whom?
- 57. How will we document deviations from the field protocol?
- 58. Which variables are most error-prone and need validation rules?
- 59. What is our plan for data versioning and rollback if errors are found?
- 60. Are sample sizes powered for key subgroups we plan to report?
- 61. Which populations are systematically missed by our sampling frame—for persons with disabilities?
- 62. What is the practical trade-off we made between representativeness and cost—for migrant workers and seasonal labour?
- 63. Where is non-response most concentrated, and is it ignorable—for linguistic minorities and low-literacy groups?

- 64. How will we diagnose and handle missingness (MCAR/MAR/MNAR)—within government frontline systems?
- 65. What is our protocol for enumerator training, drift checks, and retraining—with community-based organisations as implementers?
- 66. Which paradata fields will we collect and monitor for quality—with private providers or PPP arrangements?
- 67. How will we detect outliers without erasing meaningful heterogeneity—for rural and tribal geographies?
- 68. What proportion of records will be back-checked and by whom—for peri-urban settlements with informal tenure?
- 69. How will we document deviations from the field protocol—for conflict-affected or high-migration areas?
- 70. Which variables are most error-prone and need validation rules—for coastal and flood-prone districts?
- 71. What is our plan for data versioning and rollback if errors are found—in digital-first delivery models?
- 72. Are sample sizes powered for key subgroups we plan to report—during a rapid pilot (≤ 3 months)?

Causal Inference & Learning

- 73. What is the strongest feasible counterfactual for this setting?
- 74. Which identification assumption is most fragile and how will we probe it?
- 75. Do heterogeneous treatment effects change who benefits most?
- 76. Are there spillovers or contamination that bias effect estimates?
- 77. What pre-trends or placebo tests can we run to increase credibility?
- 78. How sensitive are results to alternative specifications or samples?
- 79. Could general equilibrium effects offset unit-level gains?
- 80. What design would we run if resources and ethics allowed (ideal design)?
- 81. How will we incorporate qualitative evidence to interpret mechanisms?
- 82. What will we learn even if results are null or negative?
- 83. How transferable are findings to other geographies or systems?
- 84. What Bayesian priors or decision thresholds reflect stakeholder beliefs?
- 85. What is the strongest feasible counterfactual for this setting—during scale-up across multiple districts?

- 86. Which identification assumption is most fragile and how will we probe it—for adolescents (10–19) and youth (15–24)?
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- 94. What will we learn even if results are null or negative—for rural and tribal geographies?
- 95. How transferable are findings to other geographies or systems—for peri-urban settlements with informal tenure?
- 96. What Bayesian priors or decision thresholds reflect stakeholder beliefs—for conflict-affected or high-migration areas?

Ethics & Safeguarding

- 97. Where are the highest-risk moments for respondents in our protocol?
- 98. How do we ensure informed consent for low-literacy participants?
- 99. When do incentives risk undue influence and how will we mitigate that?
- 100. What is our plan for incidental findings requiring duty of care?
- 101. How will we minimise and secure personally identifiable information?
- 102. What is the escalation pathway for distress or safety disclosures?
- 103. How will we debrief and support field teams after difficult encounters?
- 104. Which community voices were involved in shaping the protocol?
- 105. How will we avoid stigmatizing language in instruments and reports?
- 106. What data retention limits and deletion policies are in force?
- 107. How do we avoid re-identification when reporting small cells?

- 108. What safeguards protect children and other vulnerable groups?
- 109. Where are the highest-risk moments for respondents in our protocol—for coastal and flood-prone districts?
- 110. How do we ensure informed consent for low-literacy participants—in digital-first delivery models?
- 111. When do incentives risk undue influence and how will we mitigate that—during a rapid pilot (≤ 3 months)?
- 112. What is our plan for incidental findings requiring duty of care—during scale-up across multiple districts?
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- 118. What data retention limits and deletion policies are in force—within government frontline systems?
- 119. How do we avoid re-identification when reporting small cells—with community-based organisations as implementers?
- 120. What safeguards protect children and other vulnerable groups—with private providers or PPP arrangements?

Use, Uptake & Decision-Making

- 121. Whose decision will this evidence concretely change and when?
- 122. Which evidence formats best fit those decisions (briefs, workshops, dashboards)?
- 123. What minimum viable feedback loop will we run to enable adaptation?
- 124. Which metrics will trigger a program pivot, pause, or scale-up?
- 125. Where are risks of misuse or over-claiming highest?
- 126. Which partners must be engaged early to ensure uptake?
- 127. What incentives align evidence use with organizational goals?
- 128. How will we share uncertainty without paralysing action?

- 129. What is our plan to institutionalise learnings beyond individuals?
- 130. Which findings are time-sensitive and need rapid communication?
- 131. What is the smallest pilot that would still generate convincing evidence?
- 132. How will we measure whether decisions actually changed?
- 133. Whose decision will this evidence concretely change and when—for rural and tribal geographies?
- 134. Which evidence formats best fit those decisions (briefs, workshops, dashboards)—for peri-urban settlements with informal tenure?
- 135. What minimum viable feedback loop will we run to enable adaptation—for conflict-affected or high-migration areas?
- 136. Which metrics will trigger a program pivot, pause, or scale-up—for coastal and flood-prone districts?
- 137. Where are risks of misuse or over-claiming highest—in digital-first delivery models?
- 138. Which partners must be engaged early to ensure uptake—during a rapid pilot (≤ 3 months)?
- 139. What incentives align evidence use with organizational goals—during scale-up across multiple districts?
- 140. How will we share uncertainty without paralysing action—for adolescents (10–19) and youth (15–24)?
- 141. What is our plan to institutionalise learnings beyond individuals—for women and girls facing mobility constraints?
- 142. Which findings are time-sensitive and need rapid communication—for persons with disabilities?
- 143. What is the smallest pilot that would still generate convincing evidence—for migrant workers and seasonal labour?
- 144. How will we measure whether decisions actually changed—for linguistic minorities and low-literacy groups?

Implementation & Operations

- 145. Which activities are on the critical path and most delay-sensitive?
- 146. What dependencies on suppliers, approvals, or seasons could slip timelines?
- 147. How will we track fidelity vs adaptation at site level?
- 148. Where can we simplify processes without harming quality?
- 149. What are the recurrent pain points field staff report?

- 150. How resilient is logistics to weather, strikes, or network outages?
- 151. Which tools or scripts can automate repetitive manual steps?
- 152. What is our spares/backup plan for key equipment?
- 153. How will we onboard and upskill new implementers quickly?
- 154. What is our plan for monitoring implementer workload and burnout?
- 155. How will we verify that standard operating procedures are followed?
- 156. Which permissions or MOUs must be renewed and when?
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- 166. What is our plan for monitoring implementer workload and burnout—during scale-up across multiple districts?
- 167. How will we verify that standard operating procedures are followed—for adolescents (10–19) and youth (15–24)?
- 168. Which permissions or MOUs must be renewed and when—for women and girls facing mobility constraints?

Costs & Value for Money

- 169. What is the fully loaded cost per beneficiary delivered to the last mile?
- 170. Which cost drivers dominate the budget and can be redesigned?

- 171. What are the marginal vs average costs at different scales?
- 172. How do costs vary across sites and why?
- 173. Which activities yield the highest impact per rupee?
- 174. What is our plan for sensitivity analysis on key price assumptions?
- 175. Where can partnerships lower costs without compromising quality?
- 176. What is the payback period for key capital purchases?
- 177. How will we track unit costs over time to detect drift?
- 178. What are the opportunity costs for participants (time, travel, fees)?
- 179. Which costs are one-off vs recurrent, and how will we finance each?
- 180. How do our costs compare with credible benchmarks?
- 181. What is the fully loaded cost per beneficiary delivered to the last mile—for persons with disabilities?
- 182. Which cost drivers dominate the budget and can be redesigned—for migrant workers and seasonal labour?
- 183. What are the marginal vs average costs at different scales—for linguistic minorities and low-literacy groups?
- 184. How do costs vary across sites and why—within government frontline systems?
- 185. Which activities yield the highest impact per rupee—with community-based organisations as implementers?
- 186. What is our plan for sensitivity analysis on key price assumptions—with private providers or PPP arrangements?
- 187. Where can partnerships lower costs without compromising quality—for rural and tribal geographies?
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- 190. What are the opportunity costs for participants (time, travel, fees)—for coastal and flood-prone districts?
- 191. Which costs are one-off vs recurrent, and how will we finance each—in digital-first delivery models?
- 192. How do our costs compare with credible benchmarks—during a rapid pilot (≤ 3 months)?

Data Engineering & Governance

- 193. What is the canonical data model and its entity-relationship diagram?
- 194. How do we control schema drift as instruments evolve?
- 195. Which validation rules run at entry vs at pipeline ingestion?
- 196. What IDs (human-readable and surrogate) ensure stable joins?
- 197. How do we version datasets and ensure reproducibility end-to-end?
- 198. Which logs and metrics signal pipeline health in real time?
- 199. How will we enforce role-based access and audit trails?
- 200. What is our backup/restore strategy and RPO/RTO targets?
- 201. Where do we anonymise, pseudonymise, or aggregate—and at what step?
- 202. How do we deprecate fields safely without breaking dashboards?
- 203. What data dictionary and lineage docs are kept up to date?
- 204. How are API keys and secrets rotated and stored?
- 205. What is the canonical data model and its entity-relationship diagram—during scale-up across multiple districts?
- 206. How do we control schema drift as instruments evolve—for adolescents (10–19) and youth (15–24)?
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- 214. How do we deprecate fields safely without breaking dashboards—for rural and tribal geographies?

Qual & Mixed Methods

- 215. Which questions are better answered qualitatively in this study?

- 216. How will we sample for variation (not representativeness) in qual work?
- 217. What is our approach to saturation and when do we stop collecting?
- 218. How will we code and triangulate themes across sources?
- 219. Which lived-experience voices are missing and how will we include them?
- 220. How will we reconcile discrepancies between qual and quant findings?
- 221. What reflexivity practices will the team adopt during analysis?
- 222. Which participatory methods are appropriate and ethical here?
- 223. What is the consent process for recording and transcription?
- 224. How will we protect anonymity in quotes and narratives?
- 225. Which rapid-feedback methods can inform iteration between rounds?
- 226. How will we archive qualitative artefacts for future learning?

Monitoring, Adaptation & Risk

- 227. What are the top five risks to outcomes, ranked by likelihood × impact?
- 228. Which indicators should be watched weekly vs quarterly?
- 229. What leading signals suggest emerging harm or backlash?
- 230. How quickly can we roll back a change if harm is detected?
- 231. Which adaptation decisions are delegated vs escalated?
- 232. What scenarios (best/base/worst) guide contingency plans?
- 233. How do we ensure adaptations are documented and evaluated?
- 234. What is our approach to uncertainty communication in reviews?
- 235. Which risks are transferred (insurance), mitigated, or accepted?
- 236. What external triggers (policy, weather, prices) must be tracked?
- 237. How will we ensure continuity if key personnel leave?
- 238. What lessons will we capture in after-action reviews?

Reporting & Communication

- 239. Who is the primary audience for this report, and what do they need to do?
- 240. What is the single most important message supported by evidence?
- 241. How will we visualise uncertainty and limitations responsibly?
- 242. Which comparisons (benchmarks, baselines) are essential, which are not?

- 243. How will we prevent over-claiming causality where design is descriptive?
- 244. What data notes (source, period, definitions) must accompany each figure?
- 245. Which accessibility practices will we use (alt text, readable colors, font sizes)?
- 246. What content belongs in annexes vs main narrative?
- 247. How will we localise language and examples for audiences?
- 248. Which stakeholders should preview drafts for accuracy and tone?
- 249. What open license and citation guidance will we include?
- 250. How will we track readership and actual use post-release?

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